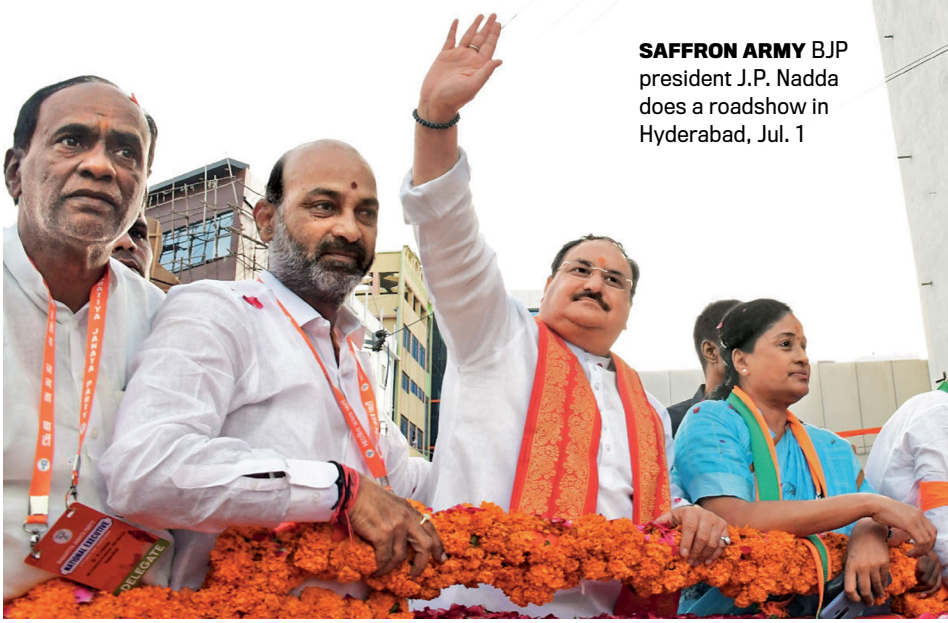
At that juncture, Nitish seemed a much enervated man and the BJP an unstoppable force. The party grabbed the Speaker's post for the first time, and even installed two deputy CMs. In another first, it also has more ministers than the JD(U) in the Nitish cabinet.

There is also a section of saffron leaders that keeps hinting at a change of guard in Bihar sooner or later. They argue that Bihar is the only major state where the BJP, despite being in government, is not leading it (Maharashtra being the other one now). And that it's time the BJP expanded its base and became *aatmanirbhar*. Another group of senior leaders concurs, but has a more realistic assessment of the Bihar political scenario and the longer term imperative of the 2024 Lok Sabha election, however alluring the prospect of *aatmanirbharta* may seem. Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan left no one in doubt when he flew into Patna on June 28 for a closed-door meeting with Nitish. "Nitishji is the leader of the NDA in Bihar," he told mediapersons. "He has the mandate to lead the government. Let there be no doubt at all."

Despite the reassurance, Nitish remains aware of the pulls and pressures in the saffron camp. His strategy to mix development with social engineering is a considered one. So while on the one hand, newspapers in Bihar these days are full of reports about Nitish resolving issues in his *janata durbars*, inaugurating new road projects, achieving new milestones in industry, burnishing his reputation as '*vikas purush*' (man of development) and '*sushasan babu*' (good administrator), on the other, his caste census is expected to bring about a social awakening. Together, they give Nitish the necessary ballast to retain the upper hand in the ruling alliance. ■



ANI

SAFFRON ARMY BJP president J.P. Nadda does a roadshow in Hyderabad, Jul. 1

BJP IN THE SOUTH

THE DECCAN CHARGE

By Amarnath K. Menon

If there is one fortress the BJP has so far had no luck breaching, it's the country below the Vindhyas, save Karnataka. Come 2023, and another possibility will open up, in Telangana. Telangana Rashtra Samithi supremo K. Chandrashekar Rao (KCR) had for a while been nurturing national ambition. But from the looks of it, he has enough on his plate to keep him on home turf. For one, there's anti-incumbency—a natural outcome of having been at the helm since the reorganisation of Andhra Pradesh in 2014. And now, smelling blood, the saffron side has been steadily amping up its decibel levels. The choice of Hyderabad as the venue for the recent meeting of the BJP national executive was part of that, as was the decision to hold the 'vijay sankalpa sabha' rally on July 2 and 3 in the Nizam's city.

The BJP has made no secret of its intent to conquer Telangana. Ever since he took charge as the state BJP president in March 2020—after becoming an MP in 2019—Bandi Sanjay has been touring the towns and villages in the state. Buoyed by the success of the vijay sankalpa sabha, many central leaders and Union ministers, some of whom were deputed to several of the 119 assembly constituencies ahead of the national executive, will likely be retracing their steps soon. As part of what the party has dubbed 'Parliament pravas yojana', the 17 Lok Sabha constituencies in the state have been divided into four functional clusters, which the Union ministers will be required to visit. They will spend three days interacting with people and booth-level party workers and ensure the message of the Union government's development and welfare programmes is disseminated to each doorstep. "Initially, the campaign will be held once in two months, then once in two weeks," says BJP leader D. Pradeep Kumar. "A pravasi minister who takes part in the campaign in one phase will not return to the same constituency in the next phase." State leaders will hold bike rallies, targeting the TRS government.

KCR has other reasons to worry. In addition to building the party machinery, the BJP is also implementing in Telangana a strategy it has used to good effect in the north—roping in influential leaders from other parties. The focus is not restricted to just a few communities, potential winners from parties of any colour are welcome.

THE BJP IS TARGETING TELANGANA AS ITS SECOND BASTION IN THE SOUTH